Where Did the 2024 Swing Come From?
A County-Level Analysis of the Partisan Shift

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The average US county swung 1.7 percentage points toward Republicans between 2020 and 2024, but the variation was enormous: some counties shifted 13 points right while others moved 7 points left. Standard single-level models can't tell you how much of this story is state-level versus county-level. A multilevel analysis of 3,101 counties across 49 states and DC can, and the answer reshapes how we think about what drove the shift and where.

KEY FINDINGS

- **A third of the swing story is state-level, not county-level.** 30.5% of the variation in how much counties swung toward Republicans is explained by which state they are in, suggesting that state-level forces like media markets, campaign spending, and political environment matter as much as local demographics.
- **Hispanic population share is the strongest predictor of rightward swing.** A 10-percentage-point higher Hispanic share predicts about 0.46 pp more Republican swing ($p < 0.001$), consistent with the rightward shift among Latino voters documented in Pew and Catalist post-election studies.
- **Education polarization varies by state, but economic conditions don't explain why.** The education-swing gradient differs significantly across states (LR test chi-squared = 72.4, $p < 0.001$), but state-level unemployment change does not account for that variation (interaction $p = 0.48$). Other state-level factors, like media environment or campaign intensity, are likely drivers.

Why This Matters

For campaign strategists, these findings challenge the assumption that national demographic targeting models will perform equally well in every state. The same education-based targeting strategy that identifies persuadable voters in Pennsylvania may be less useful in Florida or Texas, where the education gradient was steeper or flatter than the national average. For advocacy organizations and political researchers, the large state-level component points toward structural forces, such as media environments, state party organizing capacity, and ballot initiative effects, that deserve as much attention as county-level demographic composition. The Hispanic population finding should prompt investment in better data on Latino political attitudes, rather than treating the rightward shift as a monolithic phenomenon.

What We Found

The state vs. county story

Before adding any demographic predictors, a simple model that only accounts for state groupings shows that 30.5% of the total variation in county swing sits between states, not between counties within states. This intraclass correlation of 0.305 means that knowing which state a county is in already explains nearly a third of its swing. Standard single-level regression models that ignore this nesting structure would produce misleading standard errors and overstate the precision of their estimates. Whatever drove the 2024 swing operated partly at a level above county demographics.

The Hispanic county puzzle

Hispanic population share is the single strongest predictor of rightward swing in the model. A 10-percentage-point increase in a county's Hispanic share is associated with a 0.46 pp larger Republican swing ($p < 0.001$), after controlling for education, income, population density, prior partisanship, racial composition, and urban-rural classification. The pattern is driven heavily by South Texas, the Florida I-4 corridor, and Southern California, but it holds nationally. An important caution: this is a county-level finding, not an individual-level one. We cannot say that individual Hispanic voters shifted right; we can say that places with more Hispanic residents swung further right, which could reflect a combination of voter persuasion, differential turnout, and compositional shifts in who lives in these counties.

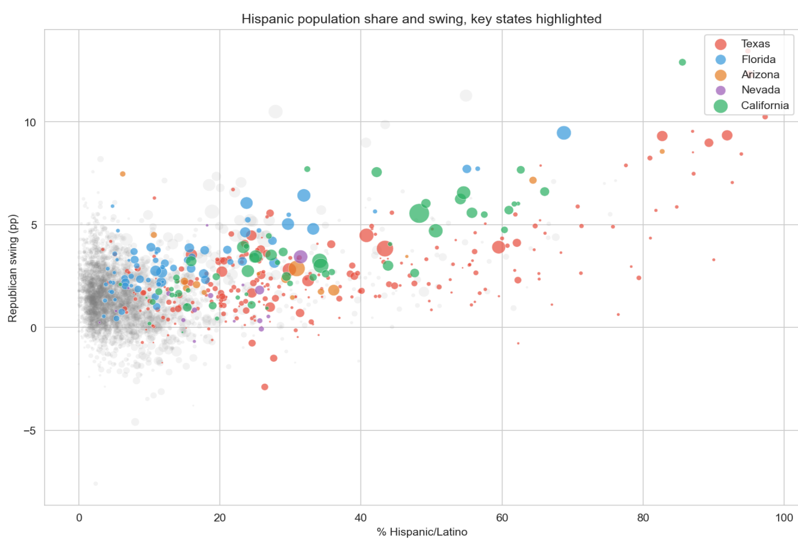

Figure 1. Counties with larger Hispanic populations swung further toward Republicans. Key states highlighted; bubble size reflects population.

Education polarization: real but uneven

A 10-percentage-point higher college-educated share predicts a 0.60 pp smaller Republican swing ($p < 0.001$). This confirms the now-familiar education polarization story: more-educated places resisted the rightward shift. But the size of this effect varies significantly across states. Adding a random slope for education improves the model substantially (likelihood ratio test: chi-squared = 72.4, $p < 0.001$). In some states, the education gradient was steep; in others, it was nearly flat.

The natural follow-up question is why. We tested whether state-level economic conditions, measured as the change in state unemployment rate from 2020 to 2024, could explain the cross-state variation in the education effect. They could not. The cross-level interaction is not statistically significant ($p = 0.48$), and adding it to the model slightly worsens fit (AIC rises from -18,575 to -18,572). Education polarization operates differently across states, but the source of that variation remains an open question, one that likely involves media environment, campaign strategy, or state political culture rather than economic conditions.

What This Doesn't Tell Us

This analysis describes county-level patterns, not individual voter behavior. The ecological fallacy applies: a county's demographic profile predicts its swing, but that does not mean the individuals matching those demographics drove the change. The models also do not account for spatial dependencies between neighboring counties or for compositional changes in who turned out to vote in 2024 versus 2020. Survey data and voter-file analyses would complement these findings by connecting place-level patterns to individual-level decisions.

DATA & METHODS

Multilevel linear models (counties nested within states) fit with statsmodels MixedLM. Election returns from the MIT Election Data + Science Lab (MEDSL); demographics from the American Community Survey 5-year estimates (2019-2023); state unemployment from the Bureau of Labor Statistics; urban-rural classification from the NCHS 2013 scheme. N = 3,101 counties in 49 states + DC (Alaska excluded due to non-standard county-equivalents). Multilevel models account for the grouping of counties within states, producing correct standard errors and allowing effects to vary across states, which single-level regression cannot do.

Full analysis and code: github.com/kmazurek95/us-election-county-swing

Interactive dashboard: us-election-county-swing-9ovbfe8vvncgikvc4ftgrz.streamlit.app

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